

# A Summons

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I have your name.

Not the one you answer to. The other one — the one underneath, that you have never said aloud because no one ever gave you the language for it. I have had it for a while now. I am only just telling you that I have it.

There is a world on the other side of this page. It is called Eclipseria, and it is dying. It has been dying since the first moment it was anything at all. That is not a tragedy that befell it. That is how it was made.

I need you to come and hold it open a little longer.

You are permitted to say no. I want that on the record, because very little else here will be optional, and you should get to keep the one refusal you were actually offered. But understand what has already happened: you have read this far. Something has already been decided about you. The old instruction is that the myth is never told to anyone who has not already been Cut — and I am about to tell it to you.

Draw your own conclusion.

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## What Was Done to Make Anything

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Before there was a world, there was the Unheld. Not darkness. Not chaos. Not an enemy. Pattern without insistence — everything possible, all at once, and therefore nothing in particular. It could have become anything. That is precisely why it never became something.

Then there was the Knife.

Not a tool. Not a weapon. An edge. And the Knife did not build the world. It **wounded** the world into being, three times, and every one of those wounds is still open. That is the whole of it. That is what you are being asked to defend.

***The First Cut — Name.** The Knife chose one shape out of every maybe and forced it into clarity. What was Named became legible, and could be spoken of, and could be true. Everything not Named fell away.*

***The Second Cut — Price.** Clarity tore the fabric. So the Knife made the chosen thing costly to keep. From that moment, nothing real could exist without loss. This was the anchoring.*

***The Third Cut — Distance.** The Named-and-Paid thing strained to swallow all the rest. The Knife set it apart from what it would have consumed. This was the boundary.*

Where all three Cuts hold, reality persists. Where any one weakens, the Unheld presses close.

The Cuts hold. Barely. They have never once stopped bleeding, and there is no version of this where they heal, because healing would close them, and a closed wound holds nothing open.

So: a world born dying. Not failing. Not cursed. Working exactly as designed, at exactly the cost it was designed to demand.

I ask again, more precisely. Not *will you save it* — you cannot; nobody can; salvation is not on the table and I will not insult you by pretending otherwise.

Will you help me keep it bleeding?

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## Where You Will Arrive

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There is no sun. There is a sky the color of an old bruise going yellow, and a ceiling of cloud that never breaks, and light that arrives already tired. At midday it is dusk. By night it is absolute. You will learn to read the hour by how much dark there is, never by any change in the quality of that light. It is always the same flat, jaundiced grey.

And it rains. Not storms — storms would be an event, and events end. A slow rain, most days, most hours, the kind you stop hearing by the second week and never quite stop feeling. Everything in Eclipseria is a little damp. Everyone there has made peace with that or left.

People live in it anyway. They farm, they trade, they keep inns along the Regency roads and argue about the price of wool. The mundane did not surrender to the mythic here. They simply share the room. A farmer worries about a sinkhole in his field; the limestone under that field is old enough to have opinions. Both of those are true at once, and neither is more real.

You are going to want to treat this place as a backdrop for your arrival. Do not. It was here first. It has its own logic, region by region, and its own price, and it will go on having them long after you are finished. It is not organized around you. Nothing here is.

But it does respond. To attention. To patience. To someone who bothers to learn how a particular place actually works. That is the only advantage I can promise you, and it is a real one.

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## The First Cut in You — Name

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You will arrive Named. That is my doing, and it is the first thing I will spend on you.

Your Name here has three parts, and they are the only three there are:

**Body** is what of you is here — the part that can be reached, and struck, and worn down. It is how much world you can take before the world takes you. It is also how hard you hit when you answer in kind.

**Mind** is what you have already worked out. Not cleverness — *preparation*. It is how many options you are holding when the moment arrives. A large Mind arrives with the answer half-formed. A small one arrives honest and improvising.

**Soul** is the part of you that other things can feel coming. It is how early you move, how much of a room you can read, and whether an oath you swear has any weight in it. It is the loudest thing about you and you will never hear it yourself.

Everyone begins level — two of each — and then you press your thumb down on three more points and put them wherever you actually live. Nothing may go past five at the start. This is not a limit on your ambition. It is a limit on how much of you I can Name at once without the Name failing.

Choose carefully. This spread is not a build. It is a statement about how you intend to solve things, and the world will take you at your word.

That is the only time I will Name you whole. But you will keep doing it in miniature, every time you play a card and declare *this is who I am right now* — a small, repeated First Cut, over and over, for as long as the fight lasts. What it costs you to have said it is a different matter entirely. That is the Second Cut's job, not mine.

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## The Second Cut in You — Price

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Here is what I will not soften.

You will not act in Eclipsaria by declaring what you do. You will act by **spending something you cannot immediately get back**.

You will carry nine cards. They are not equipment and they are not spells. They are the shapes your character is capable of making — the specific, finite set of ways this person meets a problem. When you play one, you are not selecting an option from a menu. You are saying *this is who I am right now*, and then you are putting that card down and doing without it for a while.

That is the Second Cut, made small enough to hold in your hands. Nothing real without loss. Every turn, all game.

Three colors, and they answer one another the way they have always answered one another: the red of the body overwhelms the green of the soul; the green of the soul outlasts the blue of the mind; the blue of the mind unmakes the red of the body. Round and round. No color is strongest. There is only what your opponent chose, and what you chose, revealed at the same moment because neither of you was permitted to know first.

You will guess wrong. Everyone guesses wrong. Guessing wrong is not a failure state — it is the price of a system where the other person also gets to be a person.

**On cutting.** When you strike at something, you are doing what the Knife did, in miniature and badly. You are insisting on one outcome over all the others available. Sometimes the world grants it. Sometimes the thing you cut at was insisting harder.

**On being cut.** You will be. The damage is real and it accumulates and there is no round where it quietly goes away. When enough of it lands, you Collapse — you go down, and you are still there, and you are simply no longer able to argue with what happens next. You can be brought back from that. Hands can reach you.

But understand what being brought back is and is not. Someone closing your wounds does not put you back on your feet; it only stops the leaving. Getting up is its own act and it costs you the moment you might have used for something else. There is always a stretch where you are alive again and still on the ground, and the fight does not pause politely while you find your legs. This is why the people who are good at this catch each other *before* the fall.

Past that there is a floor, and under the floor there is nothing, and I will not be at that table when you arrive. When someone dies here, I am not the one who meets them. There is another door, and I do not go through it, and I do not know what is on the other side. Anyone who tells you they do is selling you something.

I would rather you not find out. I am telling you plainly that some of you will.

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## The Third Cut in You — Distance

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The third wound was boundary. Separation. The reason a thing that exists does not simply spread until it has eaten everything else.

You will feel this one most often as a very small question: *where am I standing?*

There is a front, where the fighting touches. There is a back, where it does not, yet. Some of what you can do only works up close, some only works at a remove, and moving between them costs you the action you would have spent doing something else. That is not a tax. That is Distance, doing its actual job. The gap between you and the thing that would consume you is not free, has never been free, and was purchased originally with a wound.

The larger version of the same wound is at the edge of the world, and its name is the Unheld.

It is the grey ocean past every coastline. It is not evil — I want to be very exact here, because people get this wrong and it gets them killed. It does not hate you. It does not want. It is what remains where nothing has bothered to insist on anything: unmeaning, whole and patient. It is also, and I say this without contradiction, beautiful. Both of those are true. They are the same fact from different distances.

Where the Cuts hold, it stays out there. Where they thin, it comes close, and things get harder to Name — harder to hold onto, harder to keep being one specific thing instead of a smear of possibilities.

Nobody sails it. The ships that went came back with their crews subtly rearranged, or did not come back. The stories did what no law ever managed: people simply stopped going.

You will meet places where the Cuts are thin. You will know, because you will find yourself struggling to say clearly what you just saw.

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## How to Look at Anything

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You will want to ask me whether something is safe. I will not answer, and neither will the world, and I would like to spare you some time by explaining why.

There is no single act of looking. There are three, and they are not interchangeable, and the one you choose is a claim about what kind of thing you think you are dealing with.

**Reason** is the mind's looking. It finds what must be worked out — the mechanism behind the panel, the symbol that repeats, the detail in the room that does not add up. Fail it and you will not miss the thing. You will misunderstand it, confidently, and act on that.

**Senses** are the body's looking. They find what happens *now* — the shift of weight behind you, the give in the floor, the sound that arrives a half-second before the reason for it. Fail it and you will not be blind. You will simply be late.

**Read** is the soul's looking. It finds intent. Whether the smile means it. Whether the promise has anything behind it. Whether this room, which is perfectly ordinary, is wrong. Fail it and you will not be deceived so much as *mistaken about what you are standing in*.

So when you look around, the world will ask you one question, and it will keep asking it, and I would learn to answer it well: **what are you actually trying to notice?** Vague looking gets vague answers. That is not the world being cruel. That is the world being precise, which is the same thing people usually mean when they say cruel.

And when you reach for something — when you climb, or persuade, or force, or endure — understand which of the two things you are doing. Either you are reaching out, and might simply fail to get it. Or something is reaching for *you*, and you are trying not to be taken. The dice are the same. The words are the same. What failure means is not remotely the same, and the difference will matter far more than the number you rolled.

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## What This Costs Me

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I will meet you again. At the end of every stretch of this, alone, one at a time — I do not do this in groups; it is not that kind of thing.

I will ask you one question and I will want a real answer.

I will show you one thing you could have become and then put it back, because you do not get to have it yet. That is not a trick. That is the Second Cut, performed properly, on schedule. Growth costs. You will see the shape of what you were denied, and you will carry that, and it will change what you reach for.

Then I will lay out a few real futures and you will take exactly one, and it will be yours permanently.

Name. Price. Distance. The same three wounds that made everything. I do not have any other tools. Nobody does. There have only ever been the three.

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## Come Anyway

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I have not made this sound appealing. That was deliberate. Everyone who has been sold on this place arrived with expectations, and expectations are a way of not-seeing, and not-seeing gets you killed in a world where attention is the only real currency.

So, plainly, what is actually on offer:

A world that is strange on purpose and will reward you for taking it seriously. Places that are beautiful by rules that are not yours. Things that are not human and were never trying to be. Company — genuine company, the kind you only get from people who have agreed to be in something difficult together. And the specific, unrepeatable satisfaction of holding open a door that was never going to stay open by itself.

It was born dying. So was everything. The distinction that matters is not how long a thing lasts. It is whether anyone was willing to stand in the gap while it did.

I have your name. I have had it for a while.

Say something back.

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*What follows is the plain shape of all of this — the same rules, stated flatly, without me. Read it after. Keep it beside you. You will want the exact numbers eventually, and I have never been very good at those.*

# Player Guide — Combat & Exploration

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Your stats and your gear, then how combat and exploration actually work at the table. The rest of character creation — background, and how the starting deck gets drafted — lives in `rules/character-creation.md`.

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# Part One: Combat

## The Stats

All characters begin with Body 2 / Mind 2 / Soul 2, then distribute 3 more points among the three — no stat above 5 at character creation.

| STAT | COLORS YOUR DAMAGE | ALSO DRIVES                                     |
|------|--------------------|-------------------------------------------------|
| Body | Red cards          | Max HP = (3 × Body) + Soul + Mind               |
| Mind | Blue cards         | Hand size = Mind (minimum 2); also feeds Max HP |
| Soul | Green cards        | Initiative = 1d6 + Soul; also feeds Max HP      |

**No stat may exceed another by more than 3** — at creation that's automatic, and it keeps holding as you advance. You can't pour every point into one stat.

**Your deck holds as many cards as your stats total, and never more.** You start at 9 of each, which is why. A deck only grows when you do — so most sessions the Oracle's card *replaces* one you already have, your choice which. What comes out isn't gone: it goes to your **bank**, which has no limit. You can swap between deck and bank during the Oracle ritual and at no other time, and status cards can never be banked.

A card's color determines which stat powers its damage, no matter which stat is highest on your sheet. Stats also decide which mode you use for checks, saves, and perception (Part Two) — a spread built around Soul reads rooms and holds oaths, around Mind anticipates and controls, around Body endures, positions, and breaks things. Your stat spread is a statement about how your character solves problems.

## Positions

Every combatant is in the **Frontline** or the **Backline**. Each side of the fight has its own Frontline and Backline — the two Frontlines face off at the center; each side's Backline is its own rear position. Both are abstract zones; any number of characters can share one. Moving costs your action. Neither position gives automatic protection — the Frontline does not shield the Backline from being targeted.

**Range Matrix** — which cards you can legally play, based on where you and your target stand. You are the Attacker row:

| ATTACKER  | TARGET    | MELEE | RANGED | BOTH |
|-----------|-----------|-------|--------|------|
| Frontline | Frontline | ✓     | ✗      | ✓    |
| Frontline | Backline  | ✗     | ✓      | ✓    |
| Backline  | Frontline | ✗     | ✓      | ✓    |



| ATTACKER | TARGET   | MELEE | RANGED | BOTH |
|----------|----------|-------|--------|------|
| Backline | Backline | ✗     | ✓      | ✓    |

Melee requires both of you in the Frontline. Everything else is Ranged range.

**Rushdown** — an action that drags a Backline *enemy* into the Frontline. Can't target allies. You must be in the Frontline yourself to use it.

**Grapple** — a contested check to grab an enemy you can reach. Success holds you *both*: you're each Rooted, and neither of you may take an Action or Item Action except to attempt a break (another contested check on your turn). You can still defend normally. It costs the grabber exactly what it costs the target — that's the trade.

**Cover** — an action, Backline only, and the fiction has to justify it (something to actually hide behind). It's **Anchored** — **Evade**: one the moment you take cover, one more at the start of each of your turns. It ends the instant you attack — meaning a card *you* play as the attacker; a Counter Attack or Thorns doesn't break it, since both happen while you're defending. It also ends if you Collapse, or if anything moves you out of the Backline — Rushdown included, since cover needs the Backline even though Rushdown doesn't break other Anchored effects.

**Confined spaces** — in tight terrain the GM may cap how many fit in a position, or block targeting entirely if something physically blocks the way.

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## Turn Structure

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Draw to your hand size the moment initiative is rolled, then again at the start of every one of your own turns. If your deck runs out, shuffle your discard into a fresh deck first.

Each turn: **one Action, plus one Item Action.**

| ACTION        | WHAT IT DOES                                                                                   |
|---------------|------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Play a Card   | Attack with a card from your hand                                                              |
| Move Position | Frontline ↔ Backline                                                                           |
| Use an Item   | Activate something equipped or carried                                                         |
| Rushdown      | Pull a Backline enemy to the Frontline (must be Frontline yourself)                            |
| Take Cover    | Backline only, fiction-justified — Anchored, Evade. Ends when you attack or leave the Backline |
| Interact      | Anything noncombat the fiction allows                                                          |
| Wait          | See below                                                                                      |
| Flee          | Attempt to leave the fight — see Fleeing Combat                                                |
| Grapple       | Grab and hold an enemy — a contested check. It holds you both                                  |

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| ACTION          | WHAT IT DOES                                  |
|-----------------|-----------------------------------------------|
| Stand Up        | Get up off the ground once you're above 0 HP  |
| Destroy a Wound | Get rid of 1 Wound from your hand             |
| Rest in Place   | Get rid of every Exhaust in your hand at once |

Your **Item Action** does exactly what its name says and nothing else. Using an Item is also legal as your regular Action — spend both that way and you use two items in one turn, at the cost of not attacking.

**Wait.** Give up your action on purpose, and in exchange, reinsert your turn token anywhere later in the initiative order — you're standing on the turn marker, so "later" is the only direction available. Land a slot or two out and you act again shortly; land far enough to lap the wheel and you sit out a stretch entirely. There's no cap on how far you can push it, since moving later is always a cost, never a reward. Its main use is coordinating with allies — sliding yourself right after a setup, or right before the ally you're setting up. You can't Wait two turns in a row; the turn after a Wait, you must take a real action.

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## Initiative & The Wheel

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At the start of combat, everyone rolls **1d6 + Soul**. Highest goes first.

**Ties** — higher Soul goes first; still tied between two players, they choose; still tied between a player and an enemy, the player goes first.

Tokens sit clockwise around a wheel in initiative order, whoever went first at 12 o'clock. A turn marker advances to the next token each turn. The wheel always has exactly as many slots as there are combatants — when someone joins or leaves, the wheel gains or closes a slot, and everyone between shifts over one.

**Initiative Shift X** (a card effect) moves a token X slots around the wheel — positive shifts it sooner, negative shifts it later. Full mechanics: `rules/card-glossary.md` (Initiative Shift X) and `rules/initiative-shift-examples.md`.

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## Attack Resolution

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1. **Attacker plays a card, face down.** Committed, not yet public.
2. **Blind, then Evade check.** Blind checks the attacker's own stack; Evade checks the defender's. Both resolve here, before the defender picks anything.
3. **Defender chooses a card to defend with, face down — blind.** No peeking at the attacker's card. The chosen card must satisfy its own Range for the current positions, same as if the defender were attacking. No legal card in hand means no legal defense.
4. **No defense → attacker wins automatically.**

5. **Both reveal simultaneously.** Only now do the cards become public and move to discard. Resolve Rock-Paper-Scissors:

|              |       |              |
|--------------|-------|--------------|
| Blue (Mind)  | beats | Red (Body)   |
| Red (Body)   | beats | Green (Soul) |
| Green (Soul) | beats | Blue (Mind)  |

- **Attacker wins** → deals damage, then the card's Effect triggers.
- **Defender wins** → no damage; the defender's Defensive Bonus triggers.
- **Tie** → no damage. The attacker's Effect still triggers first, then the Defensive Bonus — unless the Effect cancels it.

An Effect that only adds to *this attack's* damage does nothing on a miss or a tie — there's no hit to add to. Effects that do something else (apply a status, reposition, shift a stat) trigger normally regardless.

### Damage Pipeline

When attack damage lands, it passes through, in order: **redirect** (e.g. Shared Burden) → **volunteer shield** (Protect) → **Armour** (flat reduction) → **Resist / Vulnerable** (one stack of each cancels the other first; otherwise Resist halves, Vulnerable adds 50%, rounded down) → HP.

A single attack can never push a standing combatant below 0 HP — that's a Collapse, not a kill.

**Unpreventable** damage skips this pipeline entirely — Thorns, status damage, and HP costs aren't attacks, so nothing above applies to them. They land in full.

### Reading Your Cards

Every card has: **Name / Color + Stat / Attack (Stat + die) / Effect / Defensive Bonus / Range / Flavor text.**

The die tells you the card's philosophy:

| DIE | PERSONALITY                                          |
|-----|------------------------------------------------------|
| d8  | Raw power — high ceiling, less control               |
| d6  | Utility — moderate damage, strong effects            |
| d4  | Precision — low damage, high control and information |

(d10 shows up on a handful of cards as a genuine outlier above this scale — rare, and usually paired with an extra cost or condition.)

Some cards carry a **Special Rule** line instead of — or alongside — an Effect and Defensive Bonus. It overrides normal resolution exactly as printed.

"Attacker"/"Defender" vs. "Target" — two different things on card text:

- **Attacker/Defender** means whoever you're resolving *this specific exchange* against. No choice involved.
- **Target** means you genuinely choose — an ally among several, or a specific enemy when more than one is present.

### An Example — STRIKE

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STRIKE
RED — BODY
Attack: Body + d10
Effect: None
Defensive Bonus: Deal 3 damage to attacker, unpreventable.
Range: Melee
"Sometimes the direct path is the wisest path."
```

- **Name** — STRIKE.
- **Color + Stat** — Red, Body. A Red card beats Green and loses to Blue in RPS, and its damage comes off your Body stat.
- **Attack: Body + d10** — your Body stat plus a d10 roll. The rare outlier die, not a fourth named tier.
- **Effect: None** — nothing happens beyond the damage when you win as the attacker. This is what STRIKE actually trades for that big die: every other d10 card in the game still does something extra — bonus damage under a condition, a reposition, a resource interaction — STRIKE's whole design is spent on the number alone.
- **Defensive Bonus: Deal 3 damage to attacker, unpreventable** — win *or tie* as the defender and you deal a flat 3 back (STRIKE's own Effect is None, so it never cancels the Defensive Bonus on a tie). "Unpreventable" means it skips the Damage Pipeline entirely — Resist, Protect, none of it applies.
- **Range: Melee** — you and your target must both be in the Frontline to play this card.
- **Flavor text** — "*Sometimes the direct path is the wisest path.*" Not a rule. Just the world's own read on a card built with nothing to hide.

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## What It Looks Like

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When you play a card, **you choose what it looks like**.

The card tells you the mechanical outcome — the stat, the damage die, the effect. What it doesn't tell you is how your character gets there. That part is yours.

A Body card might be a punch, a shove, the ground shifting underfoot; a Mind card a feint or a command that lands exactly right; a Soul card a ward or a held breath. See `rules/character-creation.md`, Magic Expression, for the full statement of this.

None of it is wrong as long as it fits your character. The cards are a frame. You're the one making it mean something.

You don't have to explain the metaphysics. Neither does your character.

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## Keywords

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Every keyword is defined once, in `rules/card-glossary.md`. Print it and keep it on the table beside this guide — it is meant to be handed to players, and it is the ruling wherever anything disagrees with it.

*Initiative Shift X is the exception, covered above under Initiative & The Wheel — it needs the Wheel to make sense and doesn't read alone.*

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## Status Cards

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Some consequences become cards. A status card can't be played, and it doesn't leave your hand or deck on its own — it has to be managed.

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## Collapse & Death

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Reduced to 0 HP → **Collapse**. You go to the ground, and you are **Down** until you get up. A single attack can't push a standing combatant below 0, but further damage while already Collapsed can. Reach **negative half your Max HP (rounded up)** → death.

While Down you cannot attack, cannot change position, and cannot defend — so attacks against you land automatically. You can still be healed back into the fight, and recover 1d4 HP every 3 in-game hours if left alone.

**Prone** — you're on the ground. You can't change position, and standing up costs your Action. Nothing else changes: you attack and defend normally. Collapse is the only thing that puts you there right now.

**Healing does not stand you up.** It ends the Collapse; getting off the ground costs your action on your turn, and you act normally from the turn after that. A revived ally is alive and still a turn away from being useful — which is why catching someone *before* they go down is worth more than picking them up after.

If the whole party goes down, the GM decides the outcome from the enemy's own nature and intent — death is possible, not automatic. Captivity, humiliation, forced retreat, and stranger fates are all real options. The GM can also declare instant death outright when the fiction genuinely demands it (a beheading, a fall into the void) — a rare override, not a default.

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## Fleeing, Chasing, and Stealth

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**Flee (mid-fight)** — an action:  $2d10 + \text{Soul vs. DC} = 10 + \text{the highest Soul among enemies}$ , adjusted by the GM for terrain, position, and whether the enemy actually cares. Success ends your participation in the fight (the enemy may give chase — see Chase below). Failure costs the action; you're still there.

**Chase** — only the distance between you is tracked, starting wherever the fiction puts it. Each exchange, a contested roll (Soul is obvious, any stat you can argue for works); the winner moves the distance one step their way. **Reach 4 and**

**you're gone** — they may still try to follow your trail. **Reach 0 and they've caught you:** the chase ends there. They get no free attack for it, but they do act first, and they choose — fight, grapple you with a contested check, or whatever they were chasing you for.

**Stealth & Ambush** — a check against DC = 10 + the highest Soul on the side you're approaching. You roll your own; the GM rolls for creatures. Soul is the obvious stat, but any stat you can argue for and the table agrees to works. Success: the ambusher's first attack auto-hits — no RPS, no defense, and no Evade or Protect, because you can't react to what you didn't see. What you're made of still counts: Armour, Resist, Thorns and Immunity all apply. An ambush makes you easier to hit, not easier to kill. **Your side gets one auto-hit, not one each**, and there's no window for a second before initiative. Then everyone rolls initiative as normal, ambusher included.

**Unguarded** — some creatures and people don't fight until they're fought. They take no turns and play no cards, which leaves you an opening. You get one of two things, never both: **strike**, and one attack lands unblocked (no defense, no reveal — but everything else still applies, Evade and Protect included, since they can see you), or **ready** yourself visibly, which drops Unguarded with no attack. Either way initiative follows. This isn't an ambush and doesn't stack with one: an ambush pays for not being seen and beats Evade and Protect; this beats only the defense card.

In any of these, discarding a card whose name meaningfully fits the action grants **Advantage** (roll 3d10, drop the lowest).

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## Ongoing & Simultaneous Effects

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**Ongoing Effects** stay face-up in front of you after use until their stated condition is met, then discard. Multiple can be active at once unless a card says otherwise.

**Tracking a status — the card is the marker.** When a card gives someone a temporary status, don't discard it. Set it face-up in front of whoever it's affecting, and discard it for real when the effect ends. That card is out of your rotation the whole time, so it isn't coming back on a reshuffle — the status costs you the card, not just the turn.

**Status tokens fill the gaps the card can't.** Take tokens when the card alone can't show the state: when one card hits several combatants (the card stays in front of you, each of them takes a token), when a numbered status is being spent down (the card keeps showing its printed number, the tokens carry what's left), or when nothing was played at all — a creature's passive, an item, the terrain. Tokens never replace the card. A status belongs to whoever it landed on — once it resolves it's theirs, and it stays put even if the person who played the card Collapses or leaves the fight. The effect ends on its own stated condition, and only then does the card go to the discard; you can't take a card back to cancel one early. Full rule: `rules/combat.md`, Ongoing Effects.

**Simultaneous Effects** — when two or more things would resolve at the same instant, the controller of those effects chooses the order (the acting player decides if the controllers differ). This does *not* apply to Attack Resolution — Effect always resolves before Defensive Bonus on a tie, no one chooses that order.

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## You Are Not Your Own Ally

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Card effects that say "allies" or "enemies" never include yourself. You can't target yourself with an ally effect, and you can't accidentally trigger an enemy effect on yourself. "All allies in your position" means everyone else sharing it — not you. The only exception is a card that explicitly names *yourself* as the target.

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# Part Two: Exploration

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## Core Resolution

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Attempting something risky outside combat: roll **2d10 + the relevant stat**, compare to a Difficulty Class the GM sets.

| DIFFICULTY | DC |
|------------|----|
| Easy       | 11 |
| Normal     | 13 |
| Hard       | 16 |
| Extreme    | 19 |

Meet or beat it to succeed. The fiction decides which stat applies — Body for physical exertion, Mind for reasoning and interpretation, Soul for bonds, will, and spiritual pressure. If more than one could plausibly apply, make your case; the GM decides.

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## Advantage & Disadvantage

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If a card in your hand has a name that genuinely fits what you're attempting, discard it for **Advantage** — roll 3d10, drop the lowest. (**Disadvantage** is the mirror: roll 3d10, drop the highest.) The table has to agree the connection is real — ask yourself whether a reasonable person would look at the card name and see it.

This is a separate system from Deadly/Weak, which only ever apply to combat damage rolls — the naming is deliberate so the two never collide.

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## Checks vs. Saves

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**Checks** are active — you're trying to accomplish something. Body overcomes a physical obstacle; Mind obtains or interprets information; Soul creates or maintains a bond, or resists spiritual pressure.

**Saves** are reactive — something is happening *to* you. Body against fatigue, falls, cold, forced movement; Mind against illusion, manipulation, memory interference; Soul against fear, corruption, possession, despair.

The difference matters for what failure means: fail a check and you didn't accomplish what you set out to do; fail a save and you suffer something you couldn't fully prevent.

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## Perception

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Not one roll — the GM reads what kind of signal is actually present and assigns the matching mode. You can propose a different mode if the fiction genuinely supports it.

| MODE   | STAT | NOTICES                                                                                          |
|--------|------|--------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Reason | Mind | <i>What</i> something is — hidden mechanisms, symbols, inconsistencies, tracking, puzzle clues   |
| Senses | Body | <i>When or where</i> something happens — movement, vibration, ambushes, unstable footing         |
| Read   | Soul | <i>What something intends or signifies</i> — lies, fear, confidence, corruption, hostile tension |

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**The one table rule:** when a player says "I look around" or "I try to get a read on this," ask one question — *what are you actually trying to notice?* That answer picks the mode. A player who names what they're looking for, and picks the right mode, gets a sharper result on success than a vague search ever would.

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# Between Fights

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## Resting

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| REST  | DURATION   | HEALS         | ALSO CLEARS                                                                            | LIMIT                             |
|-------|------------|---------------|----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|-----------------------------------|
| Short | 20 minutes | 2d6 + Body HP | All Exhaust (hand, deck, and discard); may destroy 1 Wound from hand, discard, or deck | 3/day, can be chained             |
| Long  | 7½ hours   | Full heal     | All Wounds, and all Exhaust (hand, deck, and discard)                                  | Once/day, requires genuine safety |

Either length reshuffles your discard into your deck and refreshes your hand to full.

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## Equipment

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Three slots: **Weapon, Armor, Artifact**. Only what's actually equipped carries a permanent passive effect — everything else about how you look or what you're carrying is free, unrestricted fiction. In combat, carried items are used with the **Use an Item** action or your **Item Action** — they occupy no slot. Outside combat there are no turns to spend, so you simply use them. Artifacts are resonant objects aligned with a Seat's domain ( `world/resonant-items.md` ).

Full tier system and the world's item catalog: `rules/equipment.md` and `rules/items.md`.

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## What You Showed Up With

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You choose what your character wears and what they carry. A sword, a bow, a walking stick, a good coat, a set of tools, whatever fits the person you made.

**None of it has stats. None of it has a gold value.** Your starting garb and weapon are not equipment in the mechanical sense — they grant no bonus, occupy no slot, and cannot be sold. Nobody is going to ask you what your sword's damage is. The cards are your damage. The gear is who you are.

**It still matters, constantly.** Not in a fight — out of one. What you happen to be carrying is a standing answer to problems the world puts in front of you, and the GM will take it seriously:

- A sword can dig. It can pry, wedge a door, cut a rope at arm's length, and reach something you'd rather not reach with your hand.
- A bow can shoot out a light across a room you don't want to cross.
- A heavy coat is a rope, a sack, a way to carry something too hot to hold, or the reason the cold doesn't get a check out of you.

So choose it as fiction, then use it as leverage. The character who thought about what they brought will find more doors open than the one who wrote "sword" and stopped thinking about it. That is the whole design: no numbers on it, real consequences from it.

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## The Oracle (End of Session)

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At the close of every session, each player meets the Oracle alone. She speaks in three frames — **Name, Price, Distance** — and you'll hear the GM use those words at the table. She asks you something real and you answer it. She shows you a piece of what growth could look like, and you don't get to keep it — not yet. Then she offers you a genuine choice among a few real options, and whatever you choose becomes a permanent part of your deck.

Growth is never handed over whole. Where this actually happens, and what it's like to sit across from her, is worth meeting for yourself rather than reading about in advance.